

International AS and A-level Psychology (9685) PS01 Report on the Examination

January 2025

REPORT ON THE EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL AS PSYCHOLOGY (9685) PS01 JANUARY 2025

There were some very good performances within each of the topics in this examination and across the three assessment objectives with some students demonstrating excellent understanding of the content and a good grasp of the issues facing psychology and psychological research. Psychological knowledge was the strongest skill demonstrated across all sections with the best performances being on questions assessing AO1.

AO2 skills continue to improve but is still an area to focus on. For the students who struggled with these questions the issues continue to centre around failing to engage with the scenario or simply rewriting sections of the scenario with little evidence of their psychological knowledge being used in any explanation of the behaviours described. However, there were students who were able to successfully embed their knowledge within explanations of the behaviours described by the scenarios producing very effective AO2 responses.

There continues to be a drop in performance when it comes to AO3. Less successful students made lists of simple strength or weakness statements or used generic evaluation points only. Points that are not fully explained leave the reader asking, 'so what?'. Effective evaluation points made by more successful students were clear on what point was being made, how the evidence provided made that point and what the implications of the argument are for the topic under discussion. Quality over quantity remains the key message when it comes to AO3 questions.

QUESTION 01

Most students answered this question correctly, identifying that a cognitive interview would not contain leading questions.

QUESTION 02

For this question there were some issues with students muddling up studies into different models, elements and features of memory. This resulted in answers focused on long-term memory studies instead of short-term or including capacity/coding research as opposed to duration. Some responses were so vague it was not possible to identify the study they were describing. In other cases it was possible to identify the study but the explanation of what the participants had to do was very vague and/or muddled. Students need to be clear on what is required by questions asking about procedure only, for example a number of students focused on or included details about findings and conclusions which was not relevant for this question. Successful students were able to identify a study, outline the tasks set for the participants and provide some additional detail such as numbers or ages of participants in the sample.

QUESTION 03

Successful students provided a clearly structured argument featuring relevant evidence, an explanation of how said evidence supported their argument, and why this was a strength or benefit overall. Less successful students simply described research as opposed to making an evaluative statement, or briefly stated several different evaluation points without explaining/elaborating on just one, as asked for in the question. Students are clearly able to

evaluate individual studies from a methodological perspective (internal validity and ecological validity arguments were common) but they must remember that evaluations need to be specific to the content under discussion and a paragraph that could be lifted and used as an answer to a similar question on a completely different topic with few to no changes is not effective evaluation.

QUESTION 04

Successful students provided a single clearly structured argument featuring evidence and explanation of the point being made. However, using individual differences as an argument tended to be generic at best and references to memory problems, brain injuries or degenerative disorders often lacked clarity. If students are suggesting that other factors could be affecting the behaviour being studied, there needs to be some clear and relevant suggestions of what these could be. Students who chose to use a specific study to illustrate their argument as an example of a problem with long-term memory research tended to produce stronger answers. Students need to ensure that they are using evaluative terms such as reductionism or reliability correctly/in the correct context.

QUESTION 05

There were some very strong performances on this question with accurate use of specialist terminology related to the components of the working memory model, and detailed description of the features and functions of these components and their sub-components. Application by these students went beyond linking the different tasks in the scenario to the different stores and brought in issues related to capacity or switching attention to the explanation of the ability or otherwise to perform the pairs of tasks.

For less successful students, the evaluation element of this extended response was regularly the weakest element with it being entirely generic or even absent. Arguing that a theory or model has expanded our knowledge on a topic is not effective evaluation, and when using evidence to support a theory, this must be done in such a way that clarifies how the evidence actually supports the theory.

In terms of application, less successful students did not go beyond linking the different tasks in the scenario to the different working memory stores. There was no attempt to explain why different tasks or combinations of tasks could or could not be completed.

When it came to descriptions of the model, there were some students who seemed to be muddling details of different elements, eg the central executive and episodic buffer, and some who confused the working memory model with the multi-store model. On some occasions students spent too long writing about long-term memory, it is important to remember that the working memory model is a model of short-term memory and simply makes reference to a link to long-term memory.

QUESTION 06

Most students achieved both marks for this question. Students should be reminded that the command word 'name' does not require any additional explanation, and when a question specifies the number of responses required, only this many should be given.

QUESTION 07

Most students achieved at least one mark for this question, indicating that students can correctly identify and briefly outline explanations for conformity. Less successful students produced limited definitions in terms of a desire to be liked/accepted or correct, whilst more successful students defined their chosen explanation and then went on to provide some additional information or detail along the lines of those suggested in the mark scheme. There were a small number of students who outlined types of conformity, rather than explanations of conformity, or blurred conformity and obedience. References to locus of control were not creditworthy.

QUESTION 08

Most students did well on this question gaining at least half to full marks. Successful students clearly linked a variable to its effect on conformity in the context of the scenario. However, less successful students could identify a variable and could identify where it was shown in the scenario, but could not explicitly state the effect it has on conformity. Task difficulty tended to produce the strongest answers, whilst unanimity and group size were sometimes rather muddled in explanation. Vague references to group pressure were quite common and worthy of little credit.

QUESTION 09

Some student's responses were limited to simply rephrasing the question with no evidence of additional knowledge or understanding. References to power and social hierarchy were often seen in the better student responses. Successful students explained what a legitimate authority is, how/why they are seen as legitimate and followed up with some additional information such as where our indicators/understanding of legitimate authorities comes from and/or further explanation about why they are likely to be obeyed.

QUESTION 10

Few students achieved the top band for this evaluation question. Many could demonstrate very detailed knowledge of relevant research, but this rarely gained credit unless it was explicitly linked to the explanation for obedience. Weaker students would also simply state that there is supporting evidence and would then describe the study (often in detail), but did not provide any explanation of how/why the study supports the explanation, this makes the evaluation of limited effectiveness. Students should be reminded that not using evaluative language often results in their responses reading more like an AO1 description of research studies, rather than an evaluation or argument. This often limits the responses to the lower mark band.

There were lots of responses that lost focus on what was being asked for by the question. Students should be reminded to focus on the question and sustain this focus throughout their response.

The most successful students presented supporting evidence and then critiqued this evidence with reference to what this meant for the explanation under discussion. Locus of control presented as an individual difference contributing to obedience/disobedience (which cannot be explained by legitimacy of authority) was often done well by these students.

QUESTION 11

Overall, this question was not answered well. There was a distinct lack of clarity the definition of social support and a number of students tried to answer the question by twisting their knowledge of locus of control. This suggests a general lack of knowledge linked to social support as an explanation for resisting social influence. There was insufficient detail in AO1, often limited to just defining social support.

In terms of evaluation, it was common to see descriptions of supporting evidence but no explanation or elaboration regarding what this meant for the concept being evaluated, reducing the effectiveness of the argument. Methodological strengths and weaknesses were not creditworthy unless linked back to what it meant for the explanation, most of the time these arguments ended up being entirely generic. Again, there were issues with evaluative terminology being used incorrectly or in the wrong context, eg reliability and temporal validity.

The study by Gamson et al. was included by a lot of students but was rarely used effectively. Students often failed to clearly link the findings of the study to social support as an explanation for resisting social influence, meaning it gained them limited credit.

A small number of students produced fantastic answers with detailed knowledge of the concept and relevant research findings. They also produced well-structured evaluation points, mainly based around research support and the issue of locus of control making social support, in isolation, an incomplete explanation for resisting social influence.

QUESTION 12

Many students achieved at least 2 marks for this question. It was evident that most knew what the limitations of the definition were but could not present them as a detailed argument. However, students should be reminded to avoid generic evaluation points, in this case, several students provided limitations to defining abnormality in general, opposed to providing specific limitations for the deviation from ideal mental health definition.

The limitation suggesting the definition sets an unrealistic standard was used by many students. However, this often needed better elaboration in terms of how the criteria may be unrealistic to be effective, Culture bias was another common limitation and could be done very well, but students must be careful to avoid blurring this issue with other definitions of abnormality. Students needed to focus on the issue that different cultures may have different criteria for assessing ideal mental health, and this why the definition could be seen as culturally biased.

QUESTION 13

Most students were able to correctly name definitions and most achieved half marks or higher on this question. Descriptions of the failure to function adequately definition were generally strong, however it was often limited or muddled descriptions that held students back, particularly for the deviation from social norms definition.

Successful students used examples effectively to illustrate their explanations. However, when these were used in isolation, without any additional explanation to the definition being described they became ineffective. Students must avoid blurring explanations from two definitions into one another. For example, citing behaviours that indicate a failure to function adequately as an indicator that someone is deviating from social norms, or referring to social

norms when describing statistical infrequency. This often significantly reduced the quality of their responses.

QUESTION 14

Most students were able to achieve full marks on this question. The most common combination of characteristics were anxiety and panic or avoidance. However, some students provided multiple different examples of biological evidence for panic, and only the first example could receive credit, whilst other students gave synonyms for the same characteristic e.g. anxiety and fear.

A number of students named types of phobias as opposed to characteristics of them, whilst others gave the categories of characteristic e.g. emotional, behavioural, cognitive. This is not required by the specification, and therefore seems to be causing some confusion on these types of questions.

QUESTION 15

Overall students do not seem to have a good understanding of the role of operant conditioning in phobias. Many responses simply defined operant conditioning in broader terms or defined positive and negative reinforcement with no reference to phobia maintenance.

Some students seemed to suggest that phobia maintenance results from punishment, whilst others described the acquisition of phobias as opposed to their maintenance. In responses where both positive and negative reinforcement were included, these had to be very clear about the subtle differences between the two processes, with negative reinforcement needed to be described in terms of removal of a negative stimulus being rewarding, rather than describing it purely in the terms of rewards, which would be positive reinforcement.

The most successful students could explain that avoidance of the stimulus removes the feeling of anxiety, acting as negative reinforcement and making the continued avoidance of the stimulus more likely to be repeated thus maintaining the phobia.

QUESTION 16

Systematic desensitisation seems to be relatively well understood by most students. However there was a lack of terminology and/or insufficient application to the scenario that often held student's responses back, costing marks. Students should be reminded that simply using the name of the person from the scenario as the only attempt at application is insufficient.

A small number of students described the theory behind why the therapy works (and the concept of reciprocal inhibition in particular) as opposed to focusing on how it is carried out as required by the question or confused systematic desensitisation with CBT.

QUESTION 17

Most students only achieved mark band 1 for this answer. A lack of explanation of arguments was again the main issue. The most successful answers referenced research studies that demonstrated the effectiveness of systematic desensitisation. Students who could give methodological details and accurate statistics of these studies tended to produce

the strongest responses. Quality over quantity is of relevance here. Students who presented one point in depth and clarity often achieved higher marks than those who presented several weaker evaluative points which simply stated the issue but provided no explanation or elaboration. A statement that a treatment is effective without any accompanying evidence to support this assertion is not creditworthy.

QUESTION 18

Only a small number of students were able to obtain over half marks on this question. This was primarily due to a lack of focus on the application demands of the question. AO1 presented in isolation received little credit. Students must be encouraged to present their knowledge in the context of the scenario, rather than simply outlining their knowledge and then vaguely linking it to a feature of the scenario.

Successful students identified the negative thoughts from Beck's triad from within the scenario and then explained how these could result in Farah's depression with some indication of the types of biases they would create or where the negative thoughts originated from. These students also identified the elements of the ABC model with clear explanation that Farah's beliefs result in depression due to the feelings of hopelessness generated by them.

QUESTION 19

Given the common issues seen in the AO3 skills across the paper, it was pleasantly surprising to see some of the strongest evaluations across the whole paper being presented in response to this question. Limitations of effectiveness of CBT tended to produce the best responses, but arguments linked to a lack of motivation in depressed patients being a barrier to treatment were also seen to a high standard.

Less successful students stated a limitation but often provided no further explanation or elaboration of the argument in the context of CBT. A small number of students cited the contribution of other factors to depression being ignored. However, this is an evaluation of the cognitive explanation for depression itself and not the cognitive approach to treatment. This kind of argument only worked when the student went on to suggest that a more holistic approach to therapy was needed, eg combining CBT with drug therapies, or that certain cases of depression caused by other factors such as biology cannot be successfully treated with CBT.

Students referring to the placebo effect need to be clear on what the effect is and what it shows. It is not a problem if there is a placebo effect, however, it is a problem if the treatment is no more effective than a placebo technique. Finally, students must ensure that the statements they make are factually correct, for example, CBT can and is used with children, however some students tried to claim that it cannot.